

INVERSIONS IN PRACTICE

The same C major chord in three positions — same notes, different bass note, completely different feeling and function.

C MAJOR — THREE POSITIONS

ROOT POSITION

C

G

E

C

C IN BASS

Most Stable

Grounded, conclusive. Strong arrival.
Foundation of the key.

1ST INVERSION

C/E

C

G

E

E IN BASS

Lighter

Smooth, elegant. Softens the chord.
Excellent for bass lines moving stepwise.

2ND INVERSION

C/G

E

C

G

G IN BASS

Least Stable

P4 above bass creates contextual
tension. Used in cadential 6/4 and
passing contexts.

THE FUNCTIONAL INVERSIONS — REAL-WORLD APPLICATIONS

C/E

I/3RD — TONIC SOFTENER

Bass: C → E → F

Softens I chord when scale degree 3 is in the melody. Creates a descending or stepwise bass line. Gentle, flowing.

G/B

V/7TH — LEADING TONE BASS

"Man in the Mirror" (MJ)

Bass: G/B → C

B rises stepwise to C — most elegant possible bass resolution. Dominant function preserved but smoother approach.

Em/B

III/5TH — MELANCHOLIC 5TH

"Shape of My Heart" (Sting)

Bass: G → Em/B → C

Most melancholic harmonization of scale degree 5. The B sustains, creating introspective minor flavor before release.

WHY INVERT?

Smooth Bass Lines

Inversions allow the bass to move stepwise (C-E-F-G) instead of jumping between roots. This creates more elegant, singable bass motion.

Voice Leading Efficiency

When one voice needs to hold a note or move by a small interval, inverting a chord keeps all voices moving minimally — the "law of least motion."

Harmonic Variety

The same chord in root, 1st, and 2nd inversion feel different. Inversions add harmonic variety without changing the overall harmonic function or chord quality.